

Simon Aquino

ENGINEERING LEADER · CLOUD-NATIVE PLATFORMS & DATA · REGULATED & MISSION-CRITICAL ENVIRONMENTS

London, United Kingdom (open to relocation)

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Executive Profile

Engineering leader with 16+ years across financial services, government, and high-growth technology, pairing people leadership and delivery ownership with deep cloud-native platform and data-engineering credibility. Builds engineering teams from the ground up, owns their delivery against regulated timelines, and stays close enough to the technology to lead engineers with authority, equally at home with the team and with the senior stakeholders the work answers to.

- **Team Leadership:** Builds and leads engineering teams through the lifecycle (hiring, onboarding, performance, coaching, and career development), and designed and won the organisational case to restructure a team for scale, with the new structure permanently adopted.
- **Delivery & Ownership:** Owns budget, hiring, and delivery for a regulated greenfield programme, accountable to client and executive stakeholders for outcomes against audit and regulatory deadlines.
- **Platform & Technical Depth:** Deep cloud-native expertise across GCP, AWS, and Azure (Kubernetes, Internal Developer Platforms, IaC) and secure, compliance-driven delivery (SOX, NIST, IAM), with the credibility to make and defend architectural and build/buy decisions.
- **Stakeholder & Strategy:** Translates between commercial goals and engineering execution, advising senior and C-suite stakeholders to shape roadmaps and turn technical direction into business outcomes.

Professional Experience

Haleon

London, UK

ENGINEERING MANAGER, DATA ENGINEERING (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Mar. 2026 - Present

- **Team Building & People Leadership:** Founded and grew a team of 6 engineers from zero, owning the full employee lifecycle: hiring, onboarding, performance reviews, 1:1 coaching, and career development, to build a high-performing engineering culture.
- **Greenfield Delivery & Execution:** Led the end-to-end delivery of a greenfield enterprise data platform for Identity & Access Management (IAM) governance, replacing manual audit processes with automated SOX compliance reporting (PA-02/AM-02 controls).
- **Technical Strategy & Architecture:** Defined the technical vision and platform roadmap, selecting Dagster/Python for a Medallion (Bronze/Silver/Gold) ETL pipeline on Azure (AKS, ADLS Gen2, PostgreSQL), and delivering infra via Terraform Cloud, Helm, and GitHub Actions.
- **Budget Ownership & Delivery Roadmap:** Managed the project budget and delivery scope, driving an iterative release strategy to incrementally ship production-grade data pipelines aligned to audit timelines and regulatory deadlines.
- **AI-Assisted Ways of Working:** Led the team's adoption of AI-assisted development and AI-driven code review, raising team throughput.

Barclays

London, UK

PRINCIPAL PLATFORM CONSULTANT (VIA RED BADGER)

Oct. 2025 - Mar. 2026

- **Platform Strategy & Transformation:** Drove the greenfield Internal Developer Platform (IDP) strategy for the Payments division, defining architecture patterns on AWS/Kubernetes to modernise DevEx and critical payment processing rails for high-throughput transactions.
- **Team Enablement & Coaching:** Led the transformation of a legacy software unit into Cloud-Native Platform Engineers through hands-on pair programming, mentoring the internal Tech Lead on platform strategy, team structure, and engineering best practices.
- **Technical Authority & Governance:** Acted as Technical Authority within the platform team, establishing "Golden Path" architecture standards and automated compliance frameworks to transition legacy systems into a secure, self-service ecosystem.

Haleon

London, UK

PRINCIPAL CONSULTANT, GITHUB MIGRATION (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Apr. 2025 - Sep. 2025

- **Migration Delivery:** Led the technical delivery of an enterprise GitHub migration.

JPMorgan Chase

London, UK

ENGINEERING MANAGER, CLOUD ENABLEMENT (VIA CORE ENGINEERING CONSULTING GROUP)

Apr. 2023 - Mar. 2025

- **Team Leadership & Growth:** Led and grew a Cloud Enablement engineering team to 13 engineers over two years, owning hiring, onboarding, performance reviews, 1:1 coaching, and career development to sustain a high-trust, high-delivery culture.
- **Organisational Design:** Recognised the team had outgrown its structure and built the business case to the Engineering Director to split it; the proposal was approved and the resulting teams were permanently embedded in the firm's org chart.
- **Technical Authority:** As the most senior lead in the Platform team, set technical direction for the firm-wide GCP and Kubernetes ecosystem (100+ clusters), delivered within ISO 27001/SOC 2-aligned frameworks, and mentored peer tech leads across the function.
- **Golden Path & Developer Experience:** Drove a "Golden Path" platform strategy with Crossplane and GitOps (ArgoCD) and observability via Prometheus/Grafana, lifting reliability and DevEx across teams.

- **Cross-Team Coordination:** Led the cloud infrastructure stream for Denmark’s critical Property Tax Platform, coordinating across 3 satellite teams to drive delivery autonomy and resolve cross-functional architectural blockers.
- **Strategic Cost Optimisation:** Executed a high-impact infrastructure consolidation strategy, simplifying legacy complexity to reduce monthly cloud operational costs without compromising system performance.
- **Modernisation & Security:** Eliminated high-risk technical debt by replacing brittle custom authentication with managed AWS API Gateway, establishing a standardised, secure pattern for external integrations.

Microsoft, Loveloholidays, eBay, Element Insurance, HMRC, Google

London, Berlin, Copenhagen

- **Microsoft (Principal Consultant):** Rescued a stalled on-prem to Azure migration for a major trading platform, optimising AKS/EventHubs for high-frequency throughput and condensing delivery from years to months.
- **Loveloholidays (Lead Platform Engineer):** Resolved critical latency bottlenecks in Go/Java microservices on GKE, achieving 30% performance gains through Kubernetes autoscaling optimisation.
- **eBay (Lead DevOps Engineer):** Orchestrated the migration of eBay Classifieds to GCP, architecting standardised GKE workflows for distributed European engineering teams.
- **Earlier Career:** Greenfield AWS/K8s platforms (Element Insurance), UK Gov digital tax at scale (HMRC), and Python/App Engine tooling at Google, alongside IT support that earned multiple peer bonuses.

Skills

Leadership & Strategy	Engineering Strategy, Tech Recruitment, Team Building & Scaling, Remote/Distributed Leadership, Performance Management, Executive Stakeholder Management, Vendor Strategy, Budgeting, FinOps.
Cloud & Platform	GCP (Pro Architect), AWS, Azure, Kubernetes (K8s), Internal Developer Platforms (IDP), Developer Experience (DevEx), Platform-as-a-Product, Terraform/Hashicorp, Crossplane, ArgoCD, Flux, Helm, Istio.
Architecture & Dev	Go, Python, React, Ruby, Bash, C, Java Spring Boot, Event-Driven Architecture, Distributed Systems, Microservices, API Design (gRPC/REST), Domain-Driven Design (DDD).
Ops, Security & Data	Prometheus, Grafana, Datadog, DevSecOps, Zero Trust, Identity Governance & IAM, SOX Controls, Data Pipelines (ETL/Medallion), Dagster, PostgreSQL, SRE Practices.

Education

University of Bristol

Bristol, UK

Languages

English	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
Italian	C2 - Native / Bilingual Proficiency
German	B2 - Professional Working Proficiency
Danish	A2 - Elementary Proficiency

Certificates

2025	Google Cloud Platform (GCP), Professional Cloud Architect (PCA)
2025	Google Cloud Platform (GCP), Generative AI Leader
2015	Scrum Alliance, Certified ScrumMaster (CSM)
2014	UK Government, UK Security Clearance (SC) [Previous]
2014	Red Hat, Red Hat Certified System Administrator (RHCSA)
2013	VMware, Certified Advanced Professional 5 - Data Centre Admin (VCAP5-DCA)
2013	VMware, Certified Professional 5 - Data Centre Virtualisation (VCP5-DV)
2011	Google, Python Readability (Internal Code Quality Award)